

» DEEPTHI JEEVANJI

Category: Athletics (Women's 400m T20)

Deepthi Jeevanji came into the limelight after breaking the women's 400m T20 world record on her way to winning gold at the World Championships in Kobe earlier this year.

Making her Paralympic debut, Deepthi was one of India's top prospects in track events at Stade de France, and the 20-year-old did not disappoint. She qualified for the final as the Heat 1 topper, though Türkiye's Aysel Onder broke Deepthi's world record of 55.07 seconds in another heat.

In the final, Deepthi was heading for a historic silver medal before Onder overtook her at the finish, with Ukraine's Yuliia Shuliar clinching gold.

Nevertheless, it was not just a memorable triumph for Deepthi but also for her parents, Jeevanji Yadhagiri and Jeevanji Dhanalaxmi, both daily wage labourers. Despite being advised by fellow villagers to abandon their eldest child, who was born with unusual features and intellectual impairments, the couple always stood by Deepthi. On September 3, she put Kalleda, a village in the Warangal district of Telangana, on the world map with her remarkable performance.



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» MARIYAPPAN THANGAVELU

Category: Athletics (Men's High Jump T63)

A veteran of three Paralympic Games, Mariyappan Thangavelu secured bronze in the men's high jump T63 at Paris 2024. He won gold in the men's high jump T42 category on his Paralympics debut in 2016 and followed it up with silver in Tokyo 2021 in the T63 category.

Born in Periavadagampatti in Salem, Tamil Nadu, Mariyappan was raised by his mother, who worked as a daily wage labourer to support her family of six. The 29-year-old suffered permanent disability in his right leg after an accident involving a drunk bus driver.

In 2024, Mariyappan also won gold at the World Championships in Kobe, five years after winning bronze at the 2019 World Championships in Dubai. He also has a silver medal from the Asian Para Games in Jakarta in 2018.

With this third Paralympic medal, Mariyappan now ranks among India's most successful Paralympians, joining the ranks of Avani, Devendra Jhajharia, and Joginder Singh Bedi.



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